

Reading

In Praise Of Regret

by Charlie Smith

Somehow the longing we speak of,
the look on the young woman's face that reveals her desperation,
the way my friends gives his sadness away
like a crime he can't keep from talking about,
somehow this is representative of the best in us,
as lovely and important as the spiky pink flowers
and the hydrangeas, a condition celebratory in itself,
occasion for gratitude this marvelous regret, this agony
a father tries to conceal from his children
that is exactly the experience
to be brought up at the famous dinners of family and friends,
this uncontrollable sobbing,
interrupting sleep this anguish
cut on the bias and chronic
it too, this delightful outcome, should be
given a place at the table, this honored guest
now raving among us, this fabulous sorrow,
enchancing dolor the night sweats
and feverish cries, the exhaustion
so like repose,
this heartbreak just lifting its head,
the foolish, stupefied grin of the totally bereft,
sister and kin, the lost
and now found (the foundered),
twitch and cry, the cock-eye
consequence of happiness dashed, pale
cousins weeping in shame, let us embrace you

In Praise Of Regret

There's not much I haven't heard. When I began my chaplaincy residency at Hazelden, now the Hazelden Betty Ford Foundation, one of my duties was to listen to patients' 5th steps. At the time, Hazelden focused almost exclusively on a 12 step approach for dealing with alcoholism and addiction. Patients admitted to the 30 day program were encouraged to write out all of their missteps, mistakes, errors, sins of omission and sins of commission. "Step 4. *Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.*" This 4th step was an honest reckoning with the worst parts of one's self. Since the patients were there for alcohol and drug addiction, they could buffer some of their offenses with the caveat that they'd been drunk or high. Some of their failings were just the result of being flawed human beings. We often don't live up to who we want to be. This was a tough step.

And then there was the next one. "Step 5. *Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.*" It's bad enough to admit some of these things to yourself. Now the patients were told that they needed to share them, all of them, with another living person. This is where the chaplains came in.

Chaplains at Hazelden were given special training regarding receiving a patient's 5th step. It takes skill to listen non-judgmentally when a person presents you with their worst. There is also something deeply healing about sitting in a room with another person, and putting all of your worst, awful, shameful, guilty, selfish, stupid and morally bankrupt history out there, and having that person stay with you, not go running from the room. I think this is what the religious practice of confession is supposed to be. Give a safe someone your worst and yet still be accepted, valued even.

There was a particular reason Hazelden used chaplains. All the staff are mandated reporters. There are some things that can't be kept secret --- unless that secret is spoken within the predetermined sacrament of confession. I would explain to the patients that during this one period of time, they could tell me anything, absolutely

anything, and it would stay with me. If they shared the same stories at a different time, I might have to report them. Patients made good use of this confessional time. I heard all sorts of things one usually does not hear.

And, just to spare you the concerns about ethical and moral dilemmas this could set up, as chaplains we could do counseling and help patients figure out what they needed to do about some of their past actions. Later in the 12 steps, recovering people are told to clean up any messes they can. *"Step 8. Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all."* *"Step 9. Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others."* Chaplains heard some awful stories, and we did more than just offer an absolution.

Most people, if they are honest, have instances in their lives that they aren't proud of. Most people have regrets. In the moment, we do the best we can. Later, when we have more information, or skill, or a different perspective, we wish we would have done things differently. Daniel Pink, a thinker and author, and his team set up the American Regret Project and the World Regret Survey. This collection of "more than 16,000 regrets from people in 105 countries... forms the largest pool of data ever collected about what humans regret."

Pink has a new book, *The Power of Regret: How Looking Backward Moves Us Forward* (2022). He, along with other scientists who have joined this research, postulate that spending time examining our regrets offers us ways to move beyond them. Ignoring them, or proudly declaring that we have no regrets, robs us of valuable information. *"The idea of 'no regrets' doesn't mean living with courage. It means living without reflection."*

Regret is "an emotion, and it's negative. It's a stomach-turning feeling when you look backward and you feel bad because of some decision you made, some action you took, or some action you didn't take. How is it different from guilt or disappointment? Regret is your fault."

That's the kicker. Of all the things we might feel sad about or that we wish had turned out differently, we only regret those that involved our agency, where what we did, or did not do, resulted in a negative outcome.

Of the two main sources of remorse, what we did, and what we didn't do, it's harder to fix what we did not do. If we've taken action, ill-fated as it might be, there is a better chance that we can address it on some level. When we did nothing, the opportunity to fix it is usually long gone.

One of the benefits of examining our regrets became evident in those 5th steps I heard years ago. Our regrets point to our values. We get some clarity about what really matters to us.

Paula Davis' article (Psychology Today 2/18/2022) "The 4 Major Kinds of Regret" lays it out cleanly:

Foundation Regrets: We failed to be responsible, disciplined, or forward thinking about our future. We didn't do the work, put in the time, or create the good habits that would have benefited us down the road. A lot of finance, education and health-related regrets are in this category.

Boldness Regrets: These are the chances we didn't take, the love we didn't pursue, the risks and discomforts we avoided. We wonder how things might have been if only we'd made that bold move. What if we'd traveled more? Inaction regrets outnumbered action regrets two to one.

Moral Regrets: We know that we didn't do the right thing. We took the low road. We bullied, or cheated, lied or stole, or we didn't speak up when we knew we should. While this makes up only about 10% of people's regrets, these are often the most personal and painful. Many of these are failings from much younger days that are carried around for decades. We did not live like the people we wanted to be.

Connection Regrets: These are the people, animals, places that we neglected. They mattered to us and helped us establish our sense of wholeness. The majority of the regrets land here. "I wish I'd reached out."

Most of you know that I now serve as a Hospice Chaplain. When people come to the end of their days, the things they wish they would have done differently about their lives falls into 6 primary categories:

- They are sorry that they didn't live true to themselves; they tried to live someone else's life.
- They kick themselves for working so hard and missing out on what really is important.
- They are sad that they didn't express their feelings and let themselves be known.
- They mourn that they didn't stay connected to family and friends,
- They lament not getting out of the bad relationships earlier
- And they regret that they didn't let themselves be happier.

When I researched regrets and religion I found that far too many people felt that they had wasted years on some religion that didn't suit them. It repressed their personality and their sexuality. It fostered feelings of inferiority, superiority and separation. Instead of feeding the soul and building integrity, they regretted that religion had done more harm than good.

Conversely, there were also those who wished that they had turned to their faith earlier and invested themselves deeper. They found that their religion called them to be better people, treating the earth and other beings with greater love and respect. They wish they had taken it seriously sooner.

Most of the social scientists stressed the need to own, and explore, our regrets. A number of scientists and therapists had suggested steps people can take to address their regrets. Most of it is pretty common sense... allow yourself to feel, have compassion for yourself, look at ways you have grown, ask yourself if you need to make amends. Pink even encourages readers to write out a "Regret Resume." The "dealing with regret hacks" I discovered were practical

and direct. Much of the focus rests on uncovering what we can learn from our regrets and doing better in the future.

As a religious professional, I was also struck by what I did not see. For all the self-exploration and intentionality about these big and small missteps, I didn't see anything about guilt, shame, and grief. The concept of sin was completely avoided. A couple of authors did point to self-forgiveness.

When we talk about regrets, it's not as simple as analyzing what went wrong and making an action plan to do better. Some of these remorseful events burrow into our bones, get lodged in our psyche, and distort our soul. Perhaps this was another reason Hazelden used chaplains to receive 5th steps.

Guilt is a fact when looking at our unfavorable past. Guilt may also be a feeling. Sometimes a person doesn't feel guilty. Guilt is attached to the places and times we have faltered. Intentional or not, we caused harm. Regret indicates that on some level, our own behavior has harmed us. Others may have been harmed. Guilt is a consequence of our failure. Sometimes our guilt requires that we make appropriate amends. We do what we can to clean up any mess we have made.

Shame is different from guilt. Shame is always an emotion and a judgment. It blares or whispers that the problem has gone beyond our behavior; we, ourselves, are what is wrong. Guilt acknowledges that we have failed. Shame claims that we are a failure.

I've preached about shame before. I just want to touch on one aspect of it in today's sermon. In order for shame to be healed, someone else needs to know your secret. You can't work on shame alone, using notebooks and worksheets. There is an old spiritual maxim "You're only as sick as your secrets."

Any regret that carries shame must be shared. Shared with someone safe who will remind you of your worth. Someone who will honestly hear your regret, not minimize it and brush it away, or heap on judgement, or try to stop you by telling you of something they did

that is even worse.. And shame leaves when we know we are still connected and cared for.

Remember that earlier I told you that many moral regrets are carried for decades. So often the patients telling me 5th Steps had some moral failure from when they were young, perhaps they were mean to the already ostracized kid on the bus, or they stole the favorite treasure from a relative's home. There was usually some event that unspoken, had gotten large and was proof enough of their failings as a human being. It was only after it had been shared that the regret could be "right-sized" and later released.

Suggesting that we forgive ourselves is certainly true. It just gets complicated. Forgiveness is a process, rarely a decision. Before we can forgive someone, including ourselves, first we have to grieve.

When we examine our regrets, it is important to pay attention to what has been lost. An injury always carries some sort of a cost. This is where regret and sin become entangled.

In our modern English, we really only have one word, sin; and it's loaded. The ancients had many words, each providing a fuller picture of the problem or offense. In Judeo-Christian theologies, there is a great continuum describing human failure. One of the words used for sin is an old archery term; it means "to miss the mark." We had our eyes on the bullseye and hit the horse saddle 7 yards to the right. There is the failure of falling short of someone, a bond between people is broken. There is ignorance of the law or messing up on a ritual. Along with the unintended failings, there is also weakness and being overcome. There is flat out rebellion. There are even generational misdeeds, when the sins of the parents are passed to the children. The current mental health focus of generational trauma isn't really new. Failure has ripples.

When we count the cost of our actions or inactions, it matters. Is our regret based on an honest mistake, ignorance, or a deliberate desire to harm? Was it founded in a mis-step, a mistake, or murder one?

Once we acknowledge and own what our misdeed has cost us, then we can begin the work of grieving. While forgiveness is a broad topic, I don't think we can fully forgive, even ourselves, until we fully grieve.

My favorite definition of forgiveness is "Giving up the hope for a different past." This is particularly fitting in relation to our regrets.

Returning to my Hazelden story, patients were encouraged to do 4th and 5th Steps periodically. These steps were to be repeated as needed. They weren't a "One and done" instruction. Patients would ask the chaplains, "Do I have to repeat all of this? Do I have to go through every mistake I ever made all over again?"

We would answer "No." Instead, share whatever it is that is bothering you now. If you have to talk about the same regret from the summer between 3rd and 4th grade, chances are that you haven't metabolized it. There is still work to do. However, if you have processed your regrets, learned from them, grieved over them, and integrated them, let them be. While one of our goals is to gain what we can from our failures and move on, I can assure you that we will have new regrets as we go.

Earlier I mentioned that our regrets show us what we value. Judging from the majority of regrets from the World Regret Survey, what is most important to us is what we understand is necessary for a good life. Stability. A chance to learn and grow. Doing the right thing. Love and Connection.

And finally, in praise of regrets, don't keep them to yourself. Not only is there healing in telling the right people, a burden is lifted when we learn we aren't the only ones. Our failures are not unique to us. And that is also one of the reasons we share them. We can learn from the mistakes of others. We can avoid some of the pitfalls if we listen.

May we be blessed by our regrets and share them generously with others. May we remember our common humanity and be grateful for those who sometimes show us what to avoid. May we experience

acceptance, forgiveness, healing and growth, all in praise of our regrets.

Amen and Amen